

Dark Souls II

It took a lot of hard work and creativity to come up with a title as atmospheric and hard-hitting as Dark Souls. Can this sequel hold its own with the original?



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Dark Souls II was a slight disappointment. There! We said it. It's out there now and you've read it and if you're a fan of the original, you're either sagely nodding your head in understanding or are frothing at the mouth in an agitated frenzy. However, do hear us out before crucifying us.

Dark Souls II is the sequel to one of our favourite games of all time and From Software had a LOT to live up to when creating the sequel. Strangely enough, it seems that the heavy responsibility has rattled the team a bit, resulting in a game that takes no risks but just refines the basic formula that made Dark Souls so great. And yes, there was a new team working on Dark Souls II.



At its heart, Dark Souls (and Demon Souls before it) has always been about the rock-solid combat system and gripping gameplay. The difficulty has always been more of a side-effect than a product of intent. That might sound confusing, but what we mean to say is that Dark Souls' difficulty is not contrived, it's a product of the game's design; a difficulty of the type you'd encounter playing minesweeper. The game always expected you to learn from

your mistakes and progress with the strength of your renewed knowledge. Dark Souls II is mostly the same, but the difficulty also does feel contrived at times now, making the game unnecessarily frustrating at times.

Dark Souls II does that very well, the mechanics are still as solid as we remember, the enemies as varied and as murderous, the environments as lovely, if not lovelier, to behold. But here's the catch, it somehow doesn't fit well together. This is a game where everything feels great in isolation, but lacks a cohesive structure for holding everything together. The original was a game with a foreboding atmosphere and a sense of despair and melancholy that hung heavily in the air, you felt weighed down by it. With Dark Souls II you feel like some sort of